

The Joy of the Lord Is Your Strength

Let me take you, for the next fifteen to twenty minutes, into a realm: a step into receiving things from the place called done. It will not take me long. Open to Romans 5.

Father, thank You for Your graciousness, for Your Word, and for the Holy Spirit and His ministry big in us, causing us to understand, operate in it, and causing it to become part of us. Your Word is alive.

Paul was probably slicing some of the largest pieces of meat in any of his books when he began the first chapters of Romans: chapters 1, 2, 3, and 4. Incredible verses, and many of them hard to understand.

When God gave me the keys to open them up, I found out there was a Jewish community in Rome having trouble believing that the swine-eating Gentiles, who had never kept a day of the law in their lives, had suddenly entered the same inheritance they had. When He began to show me these things, the Scriptures began to line up.

Then we get to the fifth chapter, and Paul, just like us preachers, could not resist it. He took a little side trail between two slices of meat and slipped us into some of the benefits of being redeemed.

When I picked up on this, I thought, "Goodness, You just laid it out as plainly as it can be laid out." He shows that when tribulation hits, my first response is important to how I end my journey in this place called done.

Romans 5:1 says:

Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.

Then:

By whom also we have access by faith into this grace wherein we stand, and rejoice in hope of the glory of God.

Then Paul says:

And not only so, but we glory in tribulations also.

Not only do we rejoice in the hope of the glory of God, but we glory in tribulations also. Notice, he did not say we glory for them. He said we glory when we find ourselves in them.

He says:

Knowing that tribulation worketh patience; and patience, experience; and experience, hope.

Then:

And hope maketh not ashamed; because the love of God is shed abroad in our hearts by the Holy Ghost which is given unto us.

At the entry level of any tribulation, this is what you are supposed to be doing: glorying in it. Not for it, but in it.

If I am not glorying for the tribulation but in the tribulation, then what am I glorying in? I have already gone to the end of the problem and given myself to the glory and worship of God for the answer He provided for me in the Father. That is the place called done.

The moment tribulation comes, I begin to give worship, praise, and glory to God in the middle of it. For what? For that place called done.

What does He do with you? He picks you up in His hands, takes His grace, carries you where the victory already is past all those things Paul named, and drops you off at done. This is where it was done for you on the cross. Then, after He drops you off in the victory, He goes back, gets you, and walks you through to it.

What causes Him to deposit me over there in the place called done? What I do the moment I enter the tribulation.

Paul says tribulation works patience. A better wording would be that tribulation employs patience. But tribulation will only employ patience the right way if you are doing the right thing in the tribulation.

Otherwise, the kind of patience tribulation employs is the kind where you are still patient when they bury you. "He was a patient man." Yes, but the tribulation worked the wrong kind of patience.

Tribulation works the right kind of patience only if that patience goes out and employs experience. How do I make my patience employ experience? By doing the right thing the moment the tribulation enters. I begin to worship God and glorify Him in the tribulation.

Why? Because it employs the right kind of patience, and patience goes out and employs the right kind of experience.

What kind of experience? The kind that works the Word. It tells me it is already done because He has done it before, and He will do it again. Besides that, I have already been dropped off in the place called done.

Now let us take confession another step. Patience employs experience, and experience employs hope. The kind of hope Paul is talking about, the kind that makes not ashamed, says:

Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.

In Romans 10, keeping in mind that there was a Jewish community there and Paul was presenting an unmistakable case that the Gentiles, who had never kept a word of the law, had suddenly come into inheritance, he describes two kinds of righteousness: the righteousness of the law and the righteousness of faith.

The righteousness which is by faith says:

Say not in thine heart, Who shall ascend into heaven? (that is, to bring Christ down from above:)

Or, Who shall descend into the deep? (that is, to bring up Christ again from the dead.)

I knew we were not supposed to say that, but I did not know why because I did not know what it meant.

When I found out what it meant, I saw that Paul was fluctuating between the two kinds of righteousness to prove the case of the Gentiles. Under the law, every year the high priest had to offer the same sacrifice behind the holiest of holies. If that sacrifice had stopped, there would have been no more memory of sin.

Paul was saying that God is not going to send Jesus down again and crucify Him every year, then raise Him from the dead every year, to provide salvation, healing, or victory. Faith which is righteousness says, "Do not say that in your heart," because He is not going to come and provide it again.

Somewhere along the line, you have to stop and accept that one single time He provided your salvation, your righteousness, and your healing.

One way a person does that is by taking the Word of God and disciplining himself to say what God says about him instead of what the circumstances or the problem says.

When you receive the glad tidings, you know He has already provided healing for you. He is not going to come do it again. You might as well make up your mind to receive what He has already done.

Confession is very powerful because you begin saying, "Oh no, you do not. You are not going to kill me, disease. He already died under the sickness, penalties, and pains. You cannot kill me with this. He already suffered and died. I am not taking it."

There is confession teaching that is out of this world, causing you to line your thinking and your mouth up with that one-time finished work.

When He taught me private worship, He taught me how to take confession a step further.

There had been a fight with my mind, a fight with my body, and different things I changed. With my mind, I was fighting the fight, knowing with my spirit that the Word says it is true, so it must be true. But when He taught me private worship, a transition began to take place. The joy of the Lord really became my strength.

What a difference it is to take the Word of God, know it, speak it, feel His pleasure and joy, and celebrate the position Christ attained for us from a place called done.

That is why Paul says when tribulations come, we glory in them. The first sign of tribulation hits you and says things are going to be this way for you. But if you do the right thing in the tribulation, it employs the right kind of patience, and patience goes out and employs experience.

All the time, I am combining private worship with His Word. It goes something like this:

You are not a man that You can lie. You have exalted Your Word above Your name, and I have what I say. Therefore I call myself healed. Do you hear me, devil? I call myself healed. With all my heart, Father, I thank You for loving me and providing this place for me two thousand years ago when I was yet Your enemy.

Hallelujah. I glorify You, praise You, and magnify You. I position myself at the other end of the trial in the place called done.

Where I used to have an analytical confession, now I am glorifying and magnifying the Person who redeemed me in the holy place He provided for us in the Father. I went from a clinical operation to the Person who is doing it.

Hallelujah.

Now I am magnifying the Person in the position He gave me, the place His Word describes as done.

When I jumped into the prayer closet, I ended up lying on the floor. The Lord said, "You do not know anything about worship."

I thought I did. I had read everybody's book.

He said, "You do not know anything about worship."

I said, "I am fasting."

He said, "Fasting? I did not tell you not to. Fasting cannot give you what this kind of worship does, and this kind of worship cannot give you what fasting does."

He went on through the things and told me what to do. I thought to myself, "What is a good reason to break the fast?" He said, "I am hungry."

I went into my sound booth. Every time I made an excuse, Tim would remedy it. I said, "I could do tapes a whole lot better if I had a sound room." The next day he put up this big Styrofoam sound room. It has since been replaced by a carpenter's version, but you should have seen the old Styrofoam booth. They painted it green, I think, so it would not kill you.

Tim constructed that thing in a couple of days and handed me the microphone again. Now what excuse did I have?

That was the place I went to begin this private worship. I went in, closed the door, turned off the lights, and wanted it to be just me and Him.

At first it was glorious because it lasted in short terms, not weeks and weeks. I would go in there and say, "Hallelujah. Thank You, Jesus. Glory. I love You."

Did I let myself have music? No. I let myself have nothing. Just me and Him. Why? I wanted to break into a pure vein of worship with just me and Him.

What if you get thrown in prison, chained between two people who do not shave their legs, and every time you say, "I love You, Jesus," they hit you with a chain? Is that conducive to worship? I wanted to break in.

I did fine for a while. The Lord let me run the full course so I could teach it. I had the attitude: "Do you worship? I do."

It did not take long to wear out all my patience levels for private worship. I would lie there, look at my watch once in a while, and think I must have been there for a couple of hours. Try ten minutes.

It just dragged. I checked my watch, but I was faithful. I said, "Hallelujah. Glory. I love You."

It got drier and drier as time went by.

I said, "No, I really love You. Really, I do."

It got flatter and flatter. It literally felt like my words were spatula-flat and went straight to the floor. You would have needed a spatula to try to throw them up to heaven. It did not work.

Sometimes it went on a long time like that. I would lie there saying, "I love You. I glorify You. I worship You." My mind was over here building this and solving that problem, but I kept my mouth running through those times.

I said, "I love lip service. I love You. I glorify You."

Then He started coming. When He started coming, He started staying longer. I did not have the fight I had with my mind. He stayed longer and longer.

You know the teaching. I saw a pond, and a rock landed in it. Waves went out from the rock and filled the pond.

I asked, "What is that first wave?"

He said, "That is when your spirit is permeated."

I asked about the second one.

He said, "The soul."

Then there will be a baptism of senses. The pendulum tilts from generic, sterile circumstances that have been stopping you into a sense invasion, a baptism of senses on God's side of the fence. You begin looking at the natural differently because you become aware of His presence and walk aware of Him, even in your senses.

Then I saw another wave.

I asked, "What is that?"

He said, "Geographical. It starts filling the geography."

For you avid ones taking this walk of absolute power, I know the next thing that is going to happen. I will get to teach on it.

It was not until I was on the other side, past all the dry flesh, that I began to understand. Now I enjoy so much just lifting my hands. Sometimes I cannot even get them here before He comes. There is healing in it too. I love that part.

After I came out the other side, I wanted to know what caused the driest of dry times. Why did it get so dry?

The reason it got so dry was that after a while God would retreat to the place where I was really walking. He would stay there and leave me underneath my flesh. So I would be saying, "Hallelujah. I love You. I glorify You," just like problems do. They leave you under a mountain of flesh. With all the strength you muster, you cannot seem to move it.

I could not stop. It was ordered. So I kept going.

Hallelujah. I love You.

I was under a mountain of flesh with this little voice crying out, "I love You." I chose my own battleground. I did not know what I was doing, but I chose my own battleground. I did not know I fought through all the different kinds of flesh that take your emotions for a ride and bring you to destruction.

It was sitting on me, and my voice was in there crying, "I love You. Hallelujah."

It got thinner and thinner because I would not stop. God would come around visiting and then go back, and it got thinner and thinner. One day, He did not go home.

Immediately after that, He began to teach me why preachers fall and some of the things I was talking about this morning. He began teaching me from this side of knowing Him like I had never known Him before.

When He began to teach me those things, I started understanding statements like, "The joy of the Lord is my strength."

He was showing me things, and I was understanding and receiving them about Him. It seemed to fill me. I could feel His pleasure so strongly. Not long ago, I found out what I was really feeling was the joy of the Lord that translates into strength.

Knowing this, when you enter tribulation, you glory in it. Begin to worship God and glorify the person of Jesus Christ for procuring such a final place in the Father with His blood and grace.

I am using the Word, but now I am beginning to magnify the Person of the Word. The patience employed by worshiping Him in the middle of tribulation starts working experience, which goes out and employs hope. Instead of being dismayed, throwing my arms up, and getting desperate, the joy of the Lord sustains me through His strength because I did the right thing at the entry level of the testing and tribulation.

Tribulation worked patience, and patience went out and employed experience. Strong meat belongs to those who, by reason of use, have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil.

Patience employed experience, and experience went out and employed hope. Hope began filling up with the substance of faith until a bursting took place, and the love of God went wall to wall inside my spirit. By that point, you can forget it. It is done and coming to pass.

Then Paul goes right back into the meat:

For by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin...

He stopped to slice off some victory, then went on with the foundations of why.

This has revolutionized my confession. I will go in now, and as I have learned, I will pray in tongues. It will be interwoven with speaking to and moving a mountain, then worshiping the Person by fastening Him in the place He procured for me by blood and grace. I worship Him, thank Him, and glorify Him.

The joy of the Lord sustains me through the whole process until it becomes impossible not to believe this thing is done.

How many are going to worship God a little more than you used to?

Hallelujah.

Now you can understand some of my excitement when I approach a problem. The worse and more impossible it looks, the more excited I get.

Paul says we glory in tribulations too. Not for the tribulation, but for the answer He says He has for it at the other end.

The devil would like to slap that smug look off your face.

"What do you know?"

Obviously something he does not, that failure.

Why, when the joy of the Lord can become your strength, would you take counsel from the devil?

That hopeless feeling comes in when you look at all your bills and how much money you have.

"Woe is me. Despair upon despair." One day the Lord said, "If I opened your eyes, did you know that many times that hopeless feeling has a person attached to it? Only not the flesh kind."

You give him preeminence because you start worshiping failure along with that feeling. So the angel steps back and says, "I guess they are having church."

Why would a person not let joy become their strength and sustain them until receiving? The time to receiving will get shorter and shorter when joy is your strength.

That feeling comes in and says, "Failure, failure, failure. God is not going to help you. Look at this. There is no answer. Despair."

Why agree with something like that, especially when there is a way to rise above it? The joy of the Lord really will inhabit your sanctuary and baptize all three areas, including geography.

Do you not know you are taking counsel from someone who went against God in the beginning and does not have the final say?

You need to say, "Devil, please sit down. You need counseling. You rebelled against God when you knew Him. Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil. You could not have known evil without knowing good. You rebelled against God, and you want me to take financial counseling from somebody as foolish as you? Have you read the end of the Bible? You do read, do you not? We win. You go to eternal torment. We go to the glories of heaven prepared for us from the foundation of the world."

Then say, "Watch this. I am going to turn my back on you and walk away. I am going to fasten myself at the end of this thing, and you are going to leave. You are never coming back into my geography."

You will be shocked when you speak directly to those despairing, hopeless feelings, almost like a substance, and see how they respond like a person.

Have you ever gotten so low you wanted to revel in it? "Woe is me. Please feel sorry for me. I would not tell you this if I did not trust you. You do not know how they are treating me."

Anyway, the joy of the Lord is your strength.

When you get to the place where He really begins to teach you and His joy becomes stronger and stronger, it will not matter what the devil pulls or what kind of catastrophe seems to confront you. The joy will hold. It will hold, and it will translate into your strength.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

Stand up.